usually understood through food chains or food webs. While a food chain shows one path along which energy can move through an ecosystem, food webs show all the overlapping ways that organisms live with and depend upon one another.

A. Food Chain

A food chain describes the flow of food in an ecosystem. This flow or feeding structure in an ecosystem is called '*trophic structure*'. Each level in this structure is called a trophic level. A food chain starts the movement of energy from one trophic level to the next (Figure 7.3). Example; Plant (primary producer) is eaten by a rabbit (herbivores, primary consumer), rabbit is eaten by a snake (carnivores, consumer or primary carnivore)and the snake is eaten by a hawk (tertiary consumer).

B. Food Web

A Food Web is a complex network of interconnected food chains. Food chains show a direct transfer of energy between organisms.

A chain might involve a mouse eating some seeds on the forest floor, a snake eating the mouse and later an eagle eating the snake.

With each step, some of the energy from the sun, which is trapped within the seeds, is getting passed on.

In a food web, the mouse might eat seed, or some grain, or maybe even some grass. The mouse might be eaten by a snake, or the eagle, or even a fox. The snake could be eaten by the eagle, but also might be eaten by a fox in the forest.

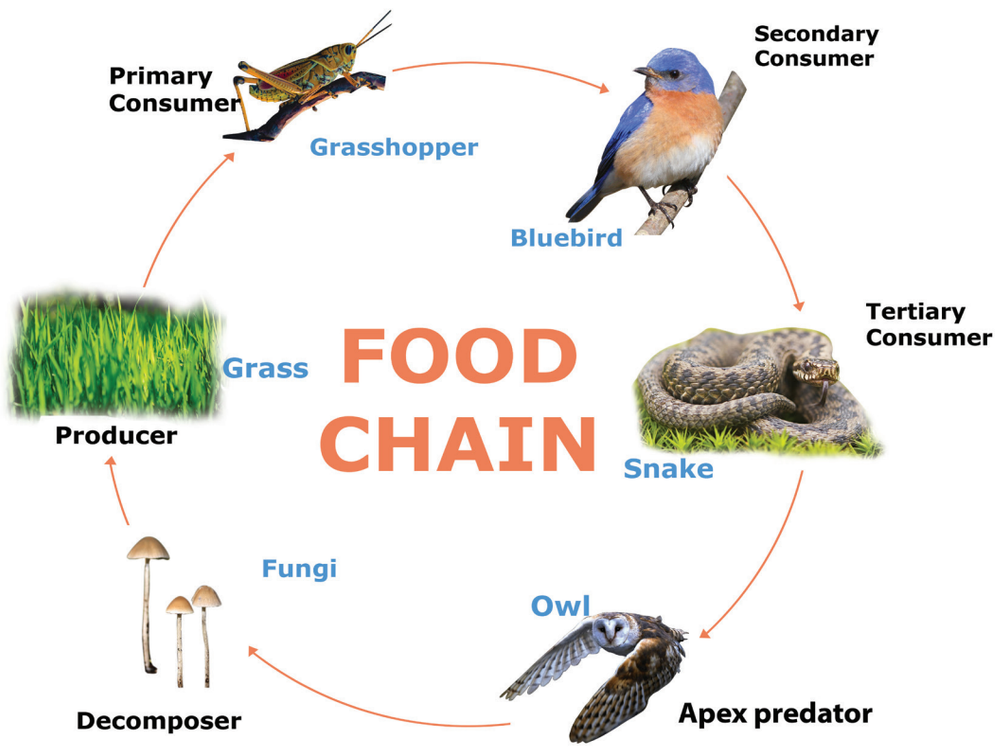


Figure 7.3 Food Chain

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